

D676

Early Literacy Methods

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

A pre-K teacher in a classroom with a new sensory table notes that a four-year-old claps syllables in “pumpkin” and names rhyming words easily. The child cannot yet say the first sound in “sun.” The child’s favorite center is blocks. Which skill is the best next step?

- A. Building words out of blocks.
- B. Segmenting every phoneme in four-sound words such as “stop.”
- C. Learning all 26 letter names.
- D. Blending and splitting onset and rime, such as /s/ + /un/.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which list orders phonological awareness skills from generally easiest to hardest?

- A. Individual phonemes → onset-rime → syllables → words in sentences
- B. Words in sentences → syllables → individual phonemes
- C. Syllables → individual phonemes → onset-rime → words in sentences
- D. Words in sentences → syllables → onset-rime → individual phonemes

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

A kindergarten teacher who uses a puppet named Pip for sound games asks, “How many sounds are in ‘check’?” The class just returned from a trip to the fire station. What is the correct answer?

- A. 5
- B. 3
- C. 4
- D. 1

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which word has four phonemes?

- A. shop
- B. stop
- C. knee
- D. light

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

A kindergartner who has beautiful, careful handwriting can read “map” when the teacher points to each letter. When asked to spell “map,” he writes only M. His class has recess right after writing time. Which skill should the teacher target to help his spelling?

- A. Blending sounds into words.
- B. Rhyming practice.
- C. More handwriting practice.
- D. Segmenting spoken words into each sound, such as /m/ /a/ /p/.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A child says /f/ /i/ /sh/ slowly but cannot say the word “fish.” Which skill needs work?

- A. Blending.
- B. Letter-sound knowledge.
- C. Segmenting.
- D. Phoneme deletion.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

A first-year kindergarten teacher who decorated her room in an ocean theme is planning the first six weeks of phonics. Which plan best fits explicit, systematic phonics?

- A. Model each stop sound with an added “uh,” such as “buh” for b.
- B. Start with a few high-use letters with clear sounds, such as m, s, a, t, model each sound, and have students blend words like “sat” within the first weeks.
- C. Read many books and let children discover letter patterns on their own.
- D. Teach one letter a week in A-to-Z order.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

During a shared reading of a big book about a farm, a pre-K teacher with a very calm voice wants to assess one child's concepts of print. Which request does that?

- A. "Show me where I should start reading, and which way I go next."
- B. "Which farm animal do you like best?"
- C. "Tell me what happened on the farm."
- D. "What letter is this?"

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

A kindergartner who loves drawing trucks writes "I LK MI DG" for "I like my dog" during journal time. Her teacher, who has 18 students, reviews the sample. What does the spelling best show?

- A. She likely has dyslexia and needs a referral now.
- B. Invented spelling is always harmful, so every error should be corrected in red.
- C. She hears and records beginning and ending consonants; short vowels in the middle are the next step.
- D. She mainly needs handwriting practice.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

While sharing a picture book on a rainy afternoon, a three-year-old points and says, "Doggy." The teacher has 12 children in her room. Which response best follows dialogic reading?

- A. "Yes, a brown dog running fast! Can you say that?"
- B. Keep reading without stopping so the story flows.
- C. "Good job," then turn the page.
- D. "Let's sound out the word dog on the page."

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A first grader who is a gifted artist and speaks in long, clever sentences has trouble rhyming, forgets letter sounds taught many times, and sometimes writes b for d. Good core instruction has been in place all year. Which part of this profile is the strongest early sign of dyslexia?

- A.** Writing b for d.
- B.** Speaking in long sentences, since dyslexia always affects spoken language.
- C.** Trouble with rhyming and retaining letter sounds despite good instruction.
- D.** Being a gifted artist.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which statement about dyslexia is accurate?

- A.** It is a vision problem in which letters look backward.
- B.** Children always outgrow it, so it is best to wait.
- C.** It stems mainly from phonological processing and responds to explicit, systematic instruction.
- D.** It reflects low overall intelligence.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer D Concept 1

A pre-K teacher ~~in a classroom with a new sensory table~~ notes that a four-year-old claps syllables in “pumpkin” and names rhyming words easily. The child cannot yet say the first sound in “sun.” ~~The child’s favorite center is blocks.~~ Which skill is the best next step?

Target word: next step on the continuum **Decides:** Syllables and rhymes are mastered; onset-rime comes next.

A	Camouflage	Uses the favorite center; it does not target the sound skill.
B	Adjacent category	Skips a level; full segmentation of blends is harder still.
C	Confusion set	Letter knowledge matters, but it is print knowledge, not the next oral sound skill.
D	Correct	Onset-rime is the next level after syllables and rhymes, before full phonemes.

2. Answer D Concept 1 • transfer

Which list orders phonological awareness skills from generally easiest to hardest?

Target word: order the continuum **Decides:** Larger units before smaller ones.

A	Inverted operation	The exact reverse.
B	Dropped element	Drops the onset-rime step.
C	Confusion set	Mixes the order of the middle levels.
D	Correct	Moves from larger to smaller units of sound.

3. Answer B Concept 2

A kindergarten teacher ~~who uses a puppet named Pip for sound games~~ asks, “How many sounds are in ‘check’?” ~~The class just returned from a trip to the fire station.~~ What is the correct answer?

Target word: count phonemes **Decides:** /ch/ /e/ /k/ — digraphs are one sound each.

A	Confusion set	Counts letters, not sounds.
B	Correct	ch = /ch/, e = /e/, ck = /k/.
C	Dropped element	Drops the rule that ck spells a single /k/.
D	Adjacent category	Counts syllables.

4. Answer B Concept 2 • transfer

Which word has four phonemes?

Target word: find the word by phoneme count — reverse of counting one word **Decides:** Each letter in s-t-o-p is its own sound.

A	Confusion set	/sh/ /o/ /p/ = 3; sh is one sound.
B	Correct	/s/ /t/ /o/ /p/ = 4.
C	Dropped element	/n/ /ē/ = 2; drops the silent k and the ee team.
D	Wrong stem number	/l/ /ī/ /t/ = 3 even though it has 5 letters.

5. Answer D Concept 3

A kindergartner ~~who has beautiful, careful handwriting~~ can read “map” when the teacher points to each letter. When asked to spell “map,” he writes only M. ~~His class has recess right after writing time.~~ Which skill should the teacher target to help his spelling?

Target word: skill that supports spelling **Decides:** Spelling needs breaking a spoken word into all its sounds.

A	Inverted operation	Blending supports reading, which he already does.
B	Adjacent category	A larger-unit skill that does not isolate each sound for spelling.
C	Camouflage	His handwriting is already strong; the gap is hearing the sounds.
D	Correct	Segmenting lets him hear and record each sound when spelling.

6. Answer A Concept 3 • transfer

A child says /f/ /i/ /sh/ slowly but cannot say the word “fish.” Which skill needs work?

Target word: name the skill from the error **Decides:** She has the parts but cannot join them.

A	Correct	Joining separate sounds into a whole word.
B	Adjacent category	The task is oral; no letters are involved.
C	Inverted operation	She already breaks the word apart.
D	Confusion set	Removing a sound is a different, harder manipulation.

7. Answer B Concept 4

A first-year kindergarten teacher ~~who decorated her room in an ocean theme~~ is planning the first six weeks of phonics. Which plan best fits explicit, systematic phonics?

Target word: choose the phonics plan **Decides:** Direct teaching in a planned sequence, high-use letters first, applied in blending.

A	Confusion set	Adding a vowel distorts sounds and makes blending harder; clip stop sounds.
B	Correct	Explicit, sequenced, and applied quickly to real words.
C	Inverted operation	Implicit exposure is the opposite of explicit teaching.
D	Adjacent category	Systematic in form, but slow and not ordered by usefulness; blending waits months.

8. Answer A Concept 5

During a shared reading of a big book about a farm, a pre-K teacher ~~with a very calm voice~~ wants to assess one child’s concepts of print. Which request does that?

Target word: a concepts-of-print check **Decides:** Concepts of print concern how books and print work.

A	Correct	Checks directionality and where print begins.
B	Camouflage	Uses the farm topic; it checks nothing about print.
C	Confusion set	Comprehension and retelling, not print concepts.
D	Adjacent category	Letter knowledge, a separate skill.

9. Answer C Concept 6

A kindergartner ~~who loves drawing trucks~~ writes “I LK MI DG” for “I like my dog” during journal time. Her teacher, ~~who has 18 students~~, reviews the sample. What does the spelling best show?

Target word: interpret the invented spelling **Decides:** Beginning and ending consonants are present; short vowels are missing.

A	Confusion set	This is a typical developmental spelling stage, not a sign of disorder.
B	Absolute language	Phonetic spelling builds phonemic awareness; it guides teaching.
C	Correct	The sample maps consonant sounds but drops medial short vowels.
D	Adjacent category	Letter formation is not the issue; sound mapping is.

10. Answer A Concept 7

While sharing a picture book ~~on a rainy afternoon~~, a three-year-old points and says, “Doggy.” ~~The teacher has 12 children in her room.~~ Which response best follows dialogic reading?

Target word: the PEER response **Decides:** Evaluate, expand, and have the child repeat.

A	Correct	Evaluates, expands the utterance, and prompts a repeat.
B	Inverted operation	Adult reads, child listens — the reverse of dialogic reading.
C	Dropped element	Drops the expansion and repeat that build language.
D	Adjacent category	Decoding practice, not oral-language expansion, and too early for a three-year-old.

11. Answer C Concept 8

A first grader ~~who is a gifted artist and speaks in long, clever sentences~~ has trouble rhyming, forgets letter sounds taught many times, and sometimes writes b for d. Good core instruction has been in place all year. Which part of this profile is the strongest early sign of dyslexia?

Target word: the key warning sign **Decides:** Phonological weakness despite good instruction.

A	Confusion set	Reversals are common in young children and are not the defining sign.
B	Absolute language	Oral language is often a strength in dyslexia.
C	Correct	Points to the phonological core of dyslexia.
D	Camouflage	Unrelated to the reading profile.

12. Answer C Concept 8 • transfer

Which statement about dyslexia is accurate?

Target word: accurate statement **Decides:** Phonological core, responds to explicit instruction.

A	Confusion set	A common myth; it is language-based.
B	Absolute language	Waiting wastes time; early intervention matters.
C	Correct	Matches the research consensus.
D	Adjacent category	Dyslexia is unrelated to intelligence.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	4	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	1	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	9	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	5	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	3	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	10	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	4	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	The phonological awareness continuum	Children generally move from larger to smaller sound units: words, syllables, onset-rime, then individual phonemes.	Jumping to full phoneme segmentation before a child can handle onset-rime.	A child who has mastered one level and a question about the next step.
2	Counting phonemes, not letters	A phoneme is a single speech sound; digraphs like sh, ch, ck count as one sound and silent letters count as none.	Counting letters as sounds.	“How many phonemes (sounds) in...?”
3	Blending vs. segmenting	Blending joins sounds into a word and supports reading; segmenting breaks a word into sounds and supports spelling.	Treating the two as the same skill or matching the wrong one to reading or spelling.	A child who can do one direction but not the other.
4	Explicit, systematic phonics	Teach letter-sound links directly in a planned simple-to-complex sequence, starting with high-use letters and clear continuous sounds, and apply them right away in blending.	Alphabetical-order letter-of-the-week or waiting for children to discover patterns.	A planned scope and sequence for beginning phonics.
5	Concepts of print	Concepts of print are knowing how books and print work: front and back, where to start, left-to-right and return sweep, and what a word is.	Confusing print concepts with letter knowledge or comprehension.	Book handling, pointing, directionality, word boundaries.
6	Invented spelling as a window	A young child’s phonetic spelling shows which sounds the child can hear and map; it guides the next instruction.	Reading early spellings as a disorder or as errors to be stamped out.	A writing sample with missing vowels or letter-name spellings.
7	Dialogic reading for oral language	In dialogic reading the adult Prompts, Evaluates, Expands, and has the child Repeat (PEER), so the child becomes the storyteller.	Reading straight through or offering only praise.	An adult responding to a child’s comment during a picture book.
8	Dyslexia’s phonological core	Dyslexia is a language-based difficulty rooted mostly in phonological processing; it is unrelated to intelligence and responds to explicit, systematic instruction.	Treating letter reversals as the key sign or seeing dyslexia as a vision problem.	Trouble rhyming, recalling letter sounds, or decoding despite good teaching.

Course scope (public description): Early Literacy Methods is a specialized course designed for educators and professionals passionate about nurturing literacy skills in young children. This course offers an in-depth exploration of the foundational concepts and practices essential for promoting literacy development in early childhood through the science of reading. Emphasizing the critical development in grades PK to third grade, the curriculum covers topics such as phonemic awareness, language acquisition, and emergent reading and writing skills. Candidates learn how to create stimulating and inclusive literacy environments, use developmentally appropriate materials, and engage with a variety of high-quality core instruction as part of Tier 1 multi-tiered systems of support and assessment (MTSS) suited to the various needs of young learners, including learners with dyslexia. Additionally, the course incorporates the latest research in early childhood literacy focusing on the science of reading and best practices for how children learn to read and write. Through a blend of theoretical knowledge and practical

application, this course aims to prepare candidates with the tools to effectively guide and inspire early literacy development in their classrooms.